NEWSMAKER OF THE YEAR 2022

INTERVIEW

GAUTAM ADANI



Then Gujarat CM Narendra Modi with Gautam Adani at a 'Vibrant Gujarat' summit in 2011

GAUTAM ADANI, billionaire industrialist and third richest man in the world, is India Today's Newsmaker of the Year. In a freewheeling interview with Group Editorial Director RAJ CHENGAPPA, he talks about the Adani Group's explosive expansion in 2022, future plans, the many controversies and even his relationship with Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Excerpts:

Q. Looking back at 2022, what makes this year so special for you?

For me, 2022 was an exceptional year in so many ways. We had a successful Adani Wilmar IPO and now it is becoming the seventh listed company in our group. We have built a business model where we start one from scratch, make it profitable and then go public. This IPO was another example of that. We also became India's second largest cement manufacturer when we acquired ACC and Ambuja Cements for around $10.5 billion (Rs 86,787 crore). It is the largest acquisition we have ever made, and it is also India's largest-ever M&A transaction in the infrastructure and materials space.

"My role is limited to formulating strategy, capital allocation and performance review. It's why I have the time to not only manage such a large organisation but also incubate new businesses"

Q. Apart from being the richest Indian and the richest Asian, you are also the world's third richest person. How does it feel to be that wealthy? What does money mean to you?

See, these rankings and numbers do not matter to me. They are only media hype. I am a first-generation entrepreneur who had to build everything from scratch. I get my thrills from handling challenges—the bigger they are, the happier I am. For me, the opportunity and ability to make a difference in the lives of people and contribute to the growth of the nation is far more satisfying and important than being on some wealth ranking or valuation list. I am thankful to God that he has given me the opportunity to serve the nation through infrastructure building.

Q. Can you define what makes you happy?

Personally speaking, this was the biggest year of my life. This year, I celebrated my 60th birthday. The personal milestone apart, my family committed Rs 60,000 crore to the Adani Foundation to support three social causes close to my heart—education, healthcare and skill development—which are foundational for any nation. This has given me immense satisfaction and happiness which no professional achievement can ever give.

Q. What motivates you in business and life?

As an ordinary man, the courage, strength, resilience and tenacity of the average Indian are very inspiring and motivating for me. To share with you, at the 2nd edition of our 'Green Talks' series, I was greatly moved by the stories of Arunima Sinha and Kiran Kanojia, two extraordinary women who, unfortunately, lost their limbs but still conquered the world. Arunima climbed Mt Everest and Kiran, a 'blade-runner', is running marathons. Both are incredible women and the pride of India. They are the real heroes of *naya* India. Their stories moved me to tears. I am truly humbled by their spirit. Could there be anything more motivating than such courage, valour